Activity: Which tool for the task? - complete text version

Build a preparation plan for four client conversations at Solitude Innovations. Match each sales task to an enablement tool by checking its audience and purpose.

Choose a task, set the audience and purpose it needs, then try a tool. Check the plan to see which constraints it meets. Revise it, then add it to your plan. You can compare any tool against any task and revisit your choices.

For a changed brief, keep your tool and switch between tasks 3 and 4. Both are internal preparation: does the same tool still meet the information need?

This activity is not graded. Your choices and optional rationale stay on this page and disappear when you reload. Do not enter personal or client information.

Build and revise your preparation plan

On paper or in a document, make four entries: task, audience, purpose, tool and reason. For each task, answer: Where in the sale is this? What information do you need? Who will see it? Choose an audience, purpose and tool from the lists below. Check both constraints using the tool descriptions. Then compare with the task feedback. If a constraint fails, revise before adding the entry to your plan. You may reuse tools; no resource quota applies. Save or copy your own rationale if you want to keep it.

Audience options

- Customer-facing - the client sees it
- Internal - mainly for your preparation

Tools and purpose options

- Pitch deck - Customer-facing - Tell a business story live
- One-pager - Customer-facing - Share a concise follow-up
- Objection-handling guide - Internal - Prepare responses to concerns
- Product quick-reference sheet - Internal - Check specific product facts

Feedback for any combination of constraints

Compare your tool’s audience with your audience setting. If they agree, read “Audience met”; otherwise read “Audience mismatch”. Compare the purpose in the same way. Compare your two settings with the task’s thinking below: if both match, read “Your constraints match”; otherwise read “Recheck the brief”. A plan can be added only when the tool, audience and purpose all fit the task. These rules apply to every combination, including customer-facing fact checks and internal follow-up summaries: none of the four tools meets both constraints in those combinations.

Audience met: this tool serves the audience you set.

Audience mismatch: customer-facing tools carry your message to the client; internal tools prepare you to answer.

Purpose met: this tool supports the job you set.

Purpose mismatch: compare the tool’s purpose with the information you need.

Your constraints match the selected task.

Recheck the brief: your audience or purpose differs from what this task needs.

This plan meets the task. You can add it to your preparation plan.

Revise the constraints or tool before adding this task to your preparation plan.

Your four-task plan is complete. Compare the two customer-facing tools and the two internal tools. Keep the audience fixed and change the information need: that is what separates the tools within each pair. In the next step, apply these distinctions to new cases.

Task 1: Opening the first presentation

You are preparing your first presentation to a client's leadership team, after the discovery call. The leadership team is cautious about adopting new technology and hesitant to commit without clear business outcomes. The company's online platform slows down during peak shopping events. You need to make a strong impression by connecting cloud benefits, such as scalability and reliability, to measurable business results rather than technical features.

Where in the sale is this?

What information do you need?

Who will see it?

Which tool do you prepare for this meeting?

- Pitch deck - Customer-facing
- One-pager - Customer-facing
- Objection-handling guide - Internal
- Product quick-reference sheet - Internal

Compare the brief with your thinking

Where in the sale is this? The opening presentation, after discovery and before the client has heard your solution.

What information do you need? The client's challenge framed in business terms, a relevant solution and documented evidence, if available, to support the proposed value. Scalability and reliability are capabilities you have explored this week.

Who will see it? The client's leadership team, live in the meeting.

Audience: Customer-facing. Purpose: Tell a business story live.

Pitch deck: Fits this task. A pitch deck tells a focused story that connects the client's problem to your solution. Its typical sections are a company overview, the customer challenge, a solution overview and proof points. For a cautious leadership team, the customer challenge slide puts the slow platform in business terms, and the proof points show results rather than features. That is what an introductory meeting needs to capture attention.

One-pager: Not the fit for this task. A one-pager is a follow-up tool. It summarises benefits on a single written page, with a value statement, key features and a call to action. It reinforces a conversation that has already happened, so it comes after this meeting.

Objection-handling guide: Not the fit for this task. This guide helps you prepare company-recommended responses to common concerns such as cost or security. The main task here is to introduce a business story to the leadership team.

Product quick-reference sheet: Not the fit for this task. This sheet helps you check product details such as uptime information or pricing. This meeting calls for a business story rather than a list of technical specifications.

Task 2: A summary for senior management

You are following up after an initial presentation. The client's operations director wants a concise summary to share with senior management before approving another meeting. The client is exploring cloud analytics to improve product development and needs something short she can pass on, linking relevant capabilities to goals such as speed, security and compliance.

Where in the sale is this?

What information do you need?

Who will see it?

Which tool do you send the operations director?

- Pitch deck - Customer-facing
- One-pager - Customer-facing
- Objection-handling guide - Internal
- Product quick-reference sheet - Internal

Compare the brief with your thinking

Where in the sale is this? Straight after the first presentation, before the client agrees to the next meeting.

What information do you need? The main message in a form the operations director can pass to people who were not in the room.

Who will see it? The operations director first, then senior management inside the client's organisation.

Audience: Customer-facing. Purpose: Share a concise follow-up.

Pitch deck: Not the fit for this task. A pitch deck is used during a live presentation. It carries the full story, and it needs you there to present it. The operations director needs something shorter that works without you.

One-pager: Fits this task. A one-pager reinforces key messages after a meeting. It typically includes a headline and value statement, relevant features, supporting evidence if available, and a call to action. Here it can summarise how proposed capabilities relate to the client's goals without promising outcomes that have not been established. A single page is easy to share with senior management, as Eli Chen demonstrated with his follow-up one-pager.

Objection-handling guide: Not the fit for this task. This guide is organised by concern and recommended response. Its main role is to prepare your team for questions; it is not the concise customer-facing summary requested here.

Product quick-reference sheet: Not the fit for this task. This sheet is used internally to confirm technical details before a meeting. It does not summarise benefits for a client to share.

Task 3: A consultation where concerns will come up

You are preparing for a second consultation with a company interested in cloud-based monitoring. Their information technology (IT) leadership team has raised concerns about cost control and data protection. You expect detailed questions about migration and compliance and need to prepare a useful, consistent response.

Where in the sale is this?

What information do you need?

Who will see it?

Which tool do you prepare from?

- Pitch deck - Customer-facing
- One-pager - Customer-facing
- Objection-handling guide - Internal
- Product quick-reference sheet - Internal

Compare the brief with your thinking

Where in the sale is this? A second consultation, where the client's concerns are the focus.

What information do you need? Company-recommended responses, supporting evidence and questions to clarify concerns about cost control, data protection, migration and compliance. Distinguish what is supported from what still needs checking.

Who will see it? Your team during preparation; the client hears your explanation.

Audience: Internal. Purpose: Prepare responses to concerns.

Pitch deck: Not the fit for this task. A pitch deck gives an overview of the solution and includes success stories. It does not hold approved responses to specific concerns.

One-pager: Not the fit for this task. A one-pager highlights benefits such as speed, cost efficiency or compliance. It does not set out specific client concerns or how to answer them.

Objection-handling guide: Fits this task. This guide lists common concerns with recommended responses, supporting evidence and follow-up prompts. It helps you prepare a consistent explanation and identify what still needs checking for this customer. You saw this preparation role in the preceding guide example.

Product quick-reference sheet: Not the fit for this task. This sheet summarises product features and service details. It helps you stay accurate, but it does not address client concerns or give you approved language for answering them.

Task 4: Minutes before a technical meeting

You are finalising your preparation for a technical meeting. The client's IT manager has emailed last-minute questions about uptime guarantees and data centre locations. You have only a few minutes to confirm accurate details before you join the call.

Where in the sale is this?

What information do you need?

Who will see it?

Which tool do you check before the call?

- Pitch deck - Customer-facing
- One-pager - Customer-facing
- Objection-handling guide - Internal
- Product quick-reference sheet - Internal

Compare the brief with your thinking

Where in the sale is this? A technical meeting, with time only for a last check.

What information do you need? Specific product details: documented uptime commitments, if any, and relevant data centre locations.

Who will see it? You use the reference to prepare an answer for the IT manager.

Audience: Internal. Purpose: Check specific product facts.

Pitch deck: Not the fit for this task. A pitch deck highlights benefits and business value. It does not hold technical detail at the level the IT manager is asking for.

One-pager: Not the fit for this task. A one-pager summarises client benefits on one page. It does not contain detailed service figures.

Objection-handling guide: Not the fit for this task. This guide prepares you to answer concerns. These are factual questions, and the guide is not where you verify specifications.

Product quick-reference sheet: Fits this task. This internal summary helps you locate service details such as documented uptime commitments, data centre locations and pricing. It is useful for a quick product-fact check; if a detail is missing or unclear, identify what needs confirmation rather than guess.

Change the brief: concerns or facts?

Keep the objection-handling guide and the internal audience. Switch from task 3 to task 4. Change the purpose from preparing responses to concerns to checking product facts. What no longer fits? The audience still fits, but the purpose no longer does. Task 4 needs the product quick-reference sheet. Reverse the switch: the sheet helps check product details but does not organise recommended responses, evidence and follow-up prompts for task 3. Use the feedback above to check each of the other tools against either brief.

Your week, sorted by audience

- Opening presentation - Pitch deck - Customer-facing
- Summary for senior management - One-pager - Customer-facing
- Consultation with concerns - Objection-handling guide - Internal
- Minutes before a technical meeting - Product quick-reference sheet - Internal

Your four-task plan is complete. Compare the two customer-facing tools and the two internal tools. Keep the audience fixed and change the information need: that is what separates the tools within each pair. In the next step, apply these distinctions to new cases.